

Academic Writing

Lesson 2: Passive



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Passive: Task 1



Change these sentences into **passive**. Compare with the active: 1) which is more suitable? 2) If passive, would you include the agent?

1. **Scientists will soon develop a vaccination for the Ebola virus.**
2. **Many politicians continue to debate the costs and necessity of net zero.**
3. **This essay will analyse the key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change.**
4. **Academics are unable to reach a consensus on the definition of intersectionality.**

1.



A: Scientists will soon develop a vaccination for the Ebola virus.

Or:

B: A vaccination for the Ebola virus will soon be developed.

Or:

C: A vaccination for the Ebola virus will soon be developed by scientists.

B is probably the most suitable. We assume scientists will do it: who else?

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2.



A: Many politicians continue to debate the costs and necessity of net zero.

Or:

B: The costs and necessity of net zero continues to be debated.

Or:

C: The costs and necessity of net zero continues to be debated by politicians.

A or **C** probably. Since this issue is widely debated by different groups, you may want to specify which groups.

If keeping the agent, then active might be better: A is 14 words, C is 15, which might be a factor also.

If this is a topic sentence, however, then passive may be better, as it focuses on the idea rather than the people involved.

3.



A: This essay will analyse the key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change.

Or:

B: The key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change will be analysed.

Or:

C: The key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change will be analysed in this essay.

A is the most suitable: as a Thesis Statement, the focus should be on the essay.

4.



A. Academics are unable to reach a consensus about on definition of intersectionality.

Or:

B. A consensus on the definition of intersectionality cannot be reached.

Or:

B. A consensus on the definition of intersectionality cannot be reached by academics.

B is probably the most suitable & saves words. Who else defines academic terms?

This said, **A** might be appropriate: referencing “academics”, “scholars” or “researchers” in this way demonstrates synthesis.

Passive: Task 2



What is more important: The event/ideas, or the agents/people involved? Why?

1) The vaccine was approved after extensive clinical trials.

The approval & its conditions matter, not who signed off.

2) The Bank of England raised interest rates in response to inflation.

A specific institutional actor made a decision; that decision-maker is the point.

3) Global temperatures have risen by over 1°C since pre-industrial levels.

The phenomenon; also, there is no agent here (nobody can 'rise' something).

4) Local residents opposed the development on environmental grounds.

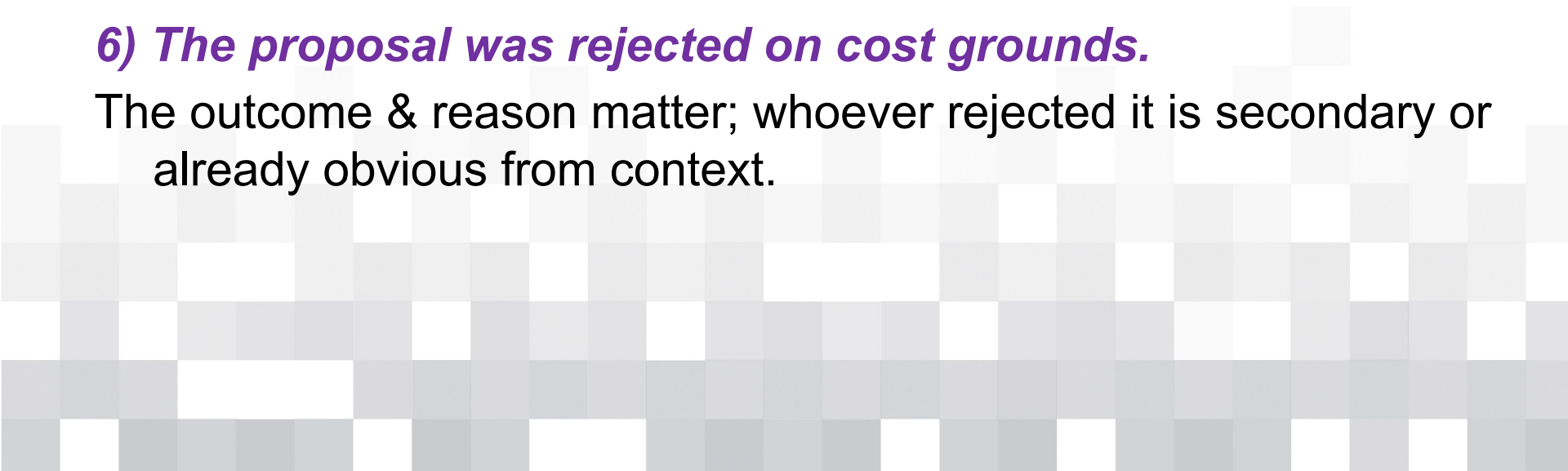
The agent's stance/action is exactly what's being reported.

5) Researchers at LSE identified several important trends.

Credit/attribution to a specific team matters, e.g. for citation or originality claims.

6) The proposal was rejected on cost grounds.

The outcome & reason matter; whoever rejected it is secondary or already obvious from context.

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Passive: Task 3



Read the two paragraphs, one active and one passive. Which is more suitable & why? What other uses of passive can you see?

Answer:

The passive is more suitable. The paragraph outlines a process; therefore, to avoid mentioning the agent (“I”), the passive must be used.

Usually, you will not have so much passive in a paragraph – the best academic example would be in your **methodology** section, when you present your **methods**.

So, how often in a paragraph do you think the passive might appear? Discuss.

Passive: Task 4



How often in a paragraph do you think the passive might appear?

Complete Task 4 for more context before we decide.

Answers

1: Use of the passive here in the topic sentence allows the writer to foreground “ICT”, the topic of the paragraph.

2: The agent (“technology”) is dropped because it’s been established earlier and is also mentioned later; it does not need repeating.

3: Passive here replaces “as we can see”, thus remaining objective. Looks academic and detached.

How often do passives appear?



It depends – but usually there are around 0-3 passive sentences in a developed paragraph. Sometimes there are more in **methods** sections, or if you are writing **explanations**.

Passives most frequently appear in the middle of paragraphs **but** are also very suitable for **topic sentences** and/or **concluding sentences**.

Passive **topic sentences** allow you to focus on the idea/issue rather than anything else, making the topic clear.

Passive **concluding sentences** allow you to hedge (write carefully) & look objective. Since concluding sentences often contain your opinion, this is useful.

Passive: Task 5



We can see that...

It can be seen that...

We discovered (that)...

It was discovered

Everybody knows (that)...

It is widely/well known

I recommend (that)...

It is highly/strongly recommended

I argue (that)...

It will be argued/It could be argued

You can assume (that)...

It can be assumed

People think (that)...

It is widely believed/held

Drafting



You have the remainder of the lesson to continue working on your draft for your assignment.

